Minimundo – Aubagne

Answers to your questions of 29 August 2026. Your questions are in blue, our answers in black.

One point before the seven questions. Aubagne is the first Minimundo, not a one-off. Our intention is to open the same concept in other French and European cities, so what we design together now is a model we will want to reproduce. That changes what we are looking for: a strong and coherent identity rather than an assembly of catalogue items, build quality that still looks good after three or four years of heavy use, and a partner we can grow with. We would rather spend more time and more money getting this first one right than repeat a compromise ten times. If it works, you are not quoting one park but the first of a series, and we are happy to discuss early what that means for both of us in terms of repeat orders, price stability and exclusivity.

1. Opening target and reverse schedule

As the target opening is December 2026, the available time for manufacturing, transportation, site preparation, installation, commissioning and final approval is very limited. We would like to discuss the key dates for: final layout approval; quotation and contract confirmation; production start; site readiness and handover for installation; installation window and final inspection before opening.

Our target is to open on **Wednesday 16 December 2026**, three days before the French Christmas school holidays start on 19 December.

Working backwards from that date — 6 to 7 weeks of sea freight to Fos-sur-Mer including customs and inland delivery, 3 weeks of installation, 10 days of statutory inspections — gives the following schedule:

- **18 September** – final layout approval, quotation confirmed, contract signed, deposit paid
- **21 September** – production starts; factory slot and freight booking confirmed; visa applications launched the same week
- **2 October** – complete document file sent to us (test reports, fire certificates, French manuals)
- **10 October** – first container leaves the factory; further containers staged, the last one by 30 October
- **15 October** – go / no-go checkpoint. If the first container has not shipped, we postpone the opening to 20 February 2027
- **13 November** – site ready and handed over to you: finished and dry floor, electrical supply points per zone, general lighting installed, HVAC running, sprinklers and fire systems installed and tested, truck access, storage room, access equipment
- **18 November to 4 December** – installation
- **7 to 11 December** – snagging, initial electrical and playground inspections by an approved body, safety commission visit and opening authorisation
- **16 December** – opening

The layout freeze on 18 September is the date that drives everything else. After that date, any change costs time rather than money.

What we need from you on this point: your real production lead time for this volume; whether you can reserve a factory slot now against a letter of intent; a firm commitment on the first shipping date; staged shipments loaded in installation order with a packing list per container; and a quotation for China–Europe rail or partial air freight as a contingency.

2. Site conditions, facilities rooms and common areas

We understand that the reception, bar, birthday rooms, changing area, restrooms, shop and storage locations are fixed. To design the overall visitor flow correctly, we would like to understand: your planned operating model and customer journey; how the reception, bar, shop and birthday rooms will be used in daily operation; whether any of these fixed areas require our design, furniture, visual treatment or equipment scope.

Operating model. Families with children aged 1 to 12, core target 3 to 10. Two-hour timed sessions at peak times (Wednesday, weekends, school holidays) with 3 to 4 rotations per day, free flow off-peak. Three revenue streams: family admissions, birthday parties, and groups — schools, holiday centres, company events and private evening hire.

Customer journey. Entrance and queuing area, then reception and ticketing, then cloakroom with lockers and non-slip socks. A short transition leads to the central square, where the whole city and the tower must be visible at once. Children then roam freely through the streets, with scheduled animations at fixed times to give the city its rhythm. The parents' bar overlooks the square and the action zone. Birthday rooms are served without crossing the queue or the play area. Visitors exit through the shop. Restrooms and baby-changing are reachable from the city without going back through reception.

Scope on these areas. To answer your question directly: **yes, we would like all of them in your scope** — reception, bar, shop, birthday rooms, cloakroom and lockers, restroom decoration, wayfinding signage and the storage areas, as well as the ceiling sky treatment. We want a single design hand and one visual world across the whole venue, not a themed city surrounded by ordinary commercial furniture. Please include design, furniture, visual treatment and equipment for these spaces.

Two practical points. The final connections — water, waste, electrical supply and ventilation, particularly for the bar — will be carried out by our French trades, so please give us your technical drawings and your supply point requirements early. And the bar is subject to French food hygiene rules on work surfaces and equipment; we will send you those requirements so your design takes them into account from the start.

Please price each of these areas on its own line, exactly as for the themed spaces, so that we can arbitrate space by space without renegotiating the whole package.

Two constraints for your layout. First, sightlines: from the bar and from a single supervision point, staff must see the square, the action zone entrance and the slide exits. Second, daily operation: storage for the props of each themed space, circulation for a cleaning trolley, and technician access.

3. Height restrictions, HVAC and emergency exits

We would like to clarify the following site constraints before starting the layout: final positions of HVAC, sprinklers, lighting, smoke detectors and other MEP services — will these be subject to our design? Required safety-clearance distances around each emergency exit and the applicable local requirements.

HVAC, sprinklers, fire detection, smoke extraction and emergency lighting are designed and installed by our French architect and engineering office, under the supervision of our control office. **They are not within your scope and their positions cannot be moved.** You design within them.

We will provide: DWG drawings of the existing building, the MEP layout with dimensions, clear heights under beams and under sprinkler heads, exit positions and escape routes, and slab constraints. Within 7 days of layout V1 we need from you: 3D envelopes in a format our engineers can use, finished heights, distributed and point loads, anchoring positions and forces, and electrical demand per zone with connection points.

The design rules to respect:

- Minimum 0.50 m left clear below all sprinkler heads, without exception.
- An enclosed structure with a solid roof blocks both extinguishing and detection. Three solutions are acceptable: a permeable roof, sprinklers underneath, or detection inside. This must be settled at layout stage with our control office and our insurer, not at delivery.
- Nothing may obstruct emergency lighting, smoke detectors, alarm sounders, extinguishers or smoke vent controls. No suspended element without prior approval.
- Escape routes keep their full width along the whole path, and the area in front of every emergency exit stays entirely clear over at least 1 m and the full width of the door. No dead end that cannot be supervised.
- The exact clearance and travel distances depend on our final ERP classification and occupancy figure. Our control office will issue them as firm constraints before the layout freeze.
- Accessibility: continuous circulation, turning areas, thresholds and counter heights according to the dimensions we will send you.

On height: the 5 m is a gross figure. After sprinkler clearance we expect **4.20 to 4.50 m genuinely usable** — please design the tower on that figure and confirm it with us before the freeze.

We would also like acoustic absorption integrated into the structures and the ceiling treatment, quoted as an option. A hall of this size with 200 children becomes unbearable for parents without it.

4. Miniature-city design direction

We understand that the project should feel like a real, connected miniature city rather than a row of separate modules. We would like to align on: the priority themed spaces and any themes you would prefer to include or exclude; the required balance between role-play, interactive games, integrated physical/soft play and free exploration; your expectations for façade detail, props, interactive elements, lighting, backlit signage and decorative street details; the desired level of material quality, durability and maintenance requirements.

The principle. We want a city plan, not a list of modules: a central square that acts as the heart, the viewpoint and the meeting point; two or three streets radiating from it; terraced façades with an apparent upper floor and lit windows; pavements and pedestrian crossings marked on the floor; street furniture — lamp posts, benches, letterbox, traffic light, kiosk, trees; backlit street signs and house numbers; a treated ceiling sky with day and night lighting scenes; ambient sound per district. Circulation forms a continuous loop: children move through the city, they do not queue in front of stands. Each trade has a shopfront on the street and an interior.

Priority spaces. Supermarket or market — the most played space everywhere, please oversize it. Fire station with truck. Veterinary clinic. Kitchen, bakery and pizzeria. Construction site, linked to the action zone. Garage, service station and vehicle circuit. TV studio and stage. Hair and beauty salon. Post office and bank. Creative workshop and school as the quiet space. Farm, garden and recycling. Station or airport. Plus a **separate 0–3 area**, physically enclosed and visible from the bar.

To exclude: any licensed theme or theme referencing a real brand; weapons and military themes; anything requiring running water or real food; sand; glass mirrors; and any fragile or detachable prop at child height. A police theme is acceptable in a civil-protection version, without weapons.

Balance of floor area: role-play 45 to 50 %, action and physical play 20 to 25 %, interactive and digital 10 %, free exploration, toddlers and circulation 20 %.

Level of detail. High. The façades, props, backlit signage, lighting scenes and street details are exactly what turns themed spaces into a city — this is where we want the budget to go. We are also interested in a game mechanic linking the spaces (wristband, missions per trade, park currency, scoreboard), but only as a priced option that is never on the critical path for opening.

Quality and maintenance. Commercial grade for 7-day operation: HPL or 18 mm birch plywood with ABS edging, no raw MDF; powder-coated steel; rounded edges and EN 1176 entrapment compliance throughout; tamper-proof fixings with all heavy props anchored; 24 V SELV lighting with accessible drivers; wipe-clean surfaces with no textiles at low level; inspection hatches. **Decorative panels must be individually demountable and replaceable, and the print files must be handed over to us** so we can reprint locally — otherwise every damaged façade becomes an order from China. Please bring physical material samples, and photographs of installations that are more than three years old rather than photographs taken at the factory.

One more expectation that follows from Aubagne being the first site: we want the design to be **documented and reproducible**. Drawings, material and colour specifications, suppliers and print files should be organised so that the identity can be rebuilt or adapted city by city rather than reinvented each time.

5. Action zone and capacity

For the action zone, including illuminated slides, construction/excavation play, ball-pit activities and a ninja course, we would like to confirm: target age groups; expected peak capacity; whether you prefer one concentrated action zone or several distributed elements, because the height (5 m) will be the main effect for the action zone; any priority equipment or experience that must be included.

Age groups. A physically separate area for 1 to 3 year olds with a soft floor and limited height; a junior circuit for 3 to 5 with reduced fall heights and its own access; the main circuit for 6 to 12. The ninja course from 6 years, with a junior line for 4 to 6, and kept below the height that would require harnesses and a lifeline — that would change our whole operating model.

Capacity. We are sizing the venue for a peak of **250 to 300 children**. The action zone must absorb 25 to 30 % of the children present at peak, which means it should be designed for **75 to 90 simultaneous users**, supervised by two staff from a single point with full visibility. Please confirm the capacity and the hourly throughput of each element so we can validate this.

One concentrated zone, plus two satellites. Height is the scarce resource in this building, so we spend it once: a landmark tower, visible from the entrance and from the bar, that acts as the signal for the whole city. Two satellites complete it — the 1 to 3 structure near the bar, and a small climb-and-slide element inside the city to relieve pressure on the tower at peak times.

Priority equipment: an LED tube slide from the top level **and** a wide racing slide with 2 or 3 lanes; a **timed ninja course with a score display**; the construction and excavation zone with excavators, conveyor and crane; a ball pit arena with cannons, including a ball cleaning and vacuum system and priced replacement balls; low-height climbing with certified impact-attenuating surfacing. Recessed trampolines only if our insurer accepts them.

Required from you: certified free fall heights and EN 1177 HIC test reports for each zone; no opaque tunnel that an adult cannot enter; rescue hatches; a written evacuation procedure from the high platforms; and maintenance access to all high points without dismantling.

6. French compliance and documentation

To prepare the correct technical and commercial proposal, we would like to clarify: the respective responsibilities of your architect, local consultants and the supplier for French ERP, PV, fire safety, accessibility and final approval; which EN, CE and test reports are required from your side; which certificates or documents must be issued locally in France; material, flooring, cleaning and maintenance requirements for daily operation.

How we see the split. The French ERP file is ours: classification and occupancy calculation, the works authorisation and safety notice, fire safety systems, smoke extraction, emergency lighting, accessibility, the initial electrical and playground inspections by an approved body, the safety commission visit and the mayor's opening authorisation, the safety register, the maintenance plan, staff training and operator insurance. These are handled by our architect, our engineering office, our control office and the local authority. You do not have to carry that file, and we are not asking you to become experts in French regulation.

What we need from you is the product documentation that allows our control office and the safety commission to sign off. This is the one area where we cannot be flexible about the result, because the opening authorisation depends on it — but we are completely open about the route to get there, and we would much rather build the list together now than discover a gap in December.

So the first thing we would like to hear from you is simply: **what do you normally provide to your European customers?** Which laboratory, which standards, and could you send us one or two sample reports? Our control office will tell us within a few days whether they can be used as they stand, and where something needs to be completed locally. That check costs nothing in September; the same check in November would be a serious problem for both of us.

Our starting list, to be discussed together:

- Test reports against EN 1176-1 to -11 and EN 1177 from a recognised third-party laboratory — ideally referenced to our own equipment, with free fall heights and safety zones shown on drawings, as generic certificates are harder for us to use in front of a commission.
- Fire reaction classification for the materials that matter most: foams, PVC and leatherette coverings, nets, floor coverings, decorative panels and suspended elements. In France this is read through EN 13501-1. If your usual reports follow a different route, send them to us and we will have them checked; where something is missing, a material can also be tested in France, provided we know early enough.
- CE declarations and French-language manuals for electrical products and for any machinery such as motorised vehicles or excavators.
- The usual compliance statements for the materials children touch: EN 71-3, REACH, and the formaldehyde class of the panels.
- A structural calculation and anchoring plan for the tower and for any suspended element.
- A handover file: as-built drawings, electrical schematics, French operating and maintenance manuals, a spare parts list with references and prices, the print files for the decoration, and cleaning instructions per material.
- Your product liability insurance certificate, and a contact in Europe if you have one.

Our only real request on timing is that the document file be complete before the goods ship, so that nothing has to be chased during installation.

Issued locally in France, by us: the works authorisation and safety notice, the initial electrical and playground verification reports, the accessibility attestation, the safety commission report and the opening order, and the safety register.

Daily operation. All surfaces wipe-clean, no textiles at low level, a ball cleaning and vacuum system for the ball pit, individually replaceable panels, a spare parts kit delivered with the park, and a maintenance and inspection plan in French with the frequencies stated, so we can register it and train our staff on it.

Installation. We want **your own installers on site in France, leading the installation**. This matters to us: nobody knows your products better, and the first Minimundo has to be assembled exactly as you intended it. We will provide a local team to work alongside them for handling, unpacking, logistics and general labour, along with site facilities, access equipment, storage and waste removal.

Everything that belongs to the building stays with our French companies: sprinklers and fire systems, plumbing, and the main electrical installation up to the supply points in each zone. Your team connects the equipment from there, with a French electrician alongside for the final connection and the certification.

On the practical side, if your technicians travel to France, Schengen visas take 4 to 8 weeks and should be launched as soon as we sign, and posted-worker formalities apply: SIPSI declaration, a representative in France, social coverage and the applicable minimum wage. Please tell us how you usually handle this for European projects and we will prepare it with you. In the quotation, please state how many of your own people you plan to send and for how many days.

7. Quotation scope

Finally, we would like to confirm the required quotation format: separate pricing by themed space; manufacturing, delivery to Aubagne, on-site installation and optional items; payment terms, warranty expectations, spare parts and after-sales support.

Format. Please issue the quotation as an Excel file, **one line per item**, with these columns: reference, themed space, description, photo, dimensions, materials, quantity, unit price, total, weight, volume in m³, HS code, production lead time, applicable standard, target age and capacity. A summary PDF alone will not let us arbitrate or reduce the scope if we have to shift the opening.

- **A. Design fees** – 2D, 3D and technical drawings. State whether they are deducted from the order. Ownership of the drawings transfers to us.
- **B. Manufacturing** – priced **separately for each themed space and for each facility area** (reception, bar, shop, birthday rooms, cloakroom, restrooms, storage, signage, ceiling treatment). This line-by-line breakdown is essential for us.
- **C. Export packing** – ISPM15, marked by zone and by installation sequence, with a packing list per container.
- **D. Freight** – quoted **both FOB Chinese port and DAP Aubagne unloaded**. Customs duties and import VAT identified separately and excluded. Incoterms 2020 stated. Priced in EUR if possible.
- **E. Installation** – the number of your own technicians and the number of days on site, plus what is included: tools, consumables, flights, accommodation, visas and per diem. Our local support team, site facilities, access equipment, storage and waste removal are on us.
- **F. Options** – each on its own line: RFID game system, scenic lighting scenes, sound system, acoustic treatment, additional themed spaces, and anything you would suggest for a later phase.
- **G. Spare parts kit** – mandatory, delivered with the park, in the order of 2 to 3 % of the contract value.
- **H. After-sales** – annual maintenance contract, guaranteed response time, cost of an on-site intervention, spare parts delivery time.

Payment terms we propose: 30 % on order after the layout freeze; 30 % at mid-production against dated progress photographs and the material test reports; 30 % against a pre-shipment inspection report and the complete document file; 10 % on clearance of snags after installation. Plus a 5 % retention for 12 months or an equivalent bank guarantee, a late delivery penalty of 0.5 % per week capped at 5 %, and a factory visit right.

Repeat orders. Since Aubagne is intended to be the first of several sites, please also tell us how long your prices remain valid and what conditions you could offer on repeat orders of the same equipment.

Warranty expectations: 5 years on steel structures, 3 years on decoration and joinery, 2 years on foams, textiles and moving parts, 1 year on electronics and LED. Wear parts excluded, with the list of wear parts annexed to avoid any later discussion. Spare parts availability guaranteed for 10 years, and shipping of warranty parts at your cost during the first year.